“Close your eyes and hold out your hands.” She obeyed, feeling a weight in her palms. “Now, open your eyes.”

Her breath caught at the green ribbon tied around the package’s brown paper. It had *Pastels Girault* printed in white ink—the art supply shop in the medieval part of Orléans. Every time she walked by, she would stop and stare through the window at the treasures on the other side of the glass, dreaming of what she might have, or could become, if she kept drawing. Her eyes flew up to meet his.

“Open it.”

Unwrapping the brown paper, she found a white rectangular box of twelve pastels. Her breath hitched as she slid the tray out, revealing indented rows holding individually wrapped crayons in exquisite colors. “*Mon Dieu*. The blues. Three shades. Each has its own number.”

André grinned. “There’s a world of difference between number three hundred and fifty-three blue and number two hundred and eighty-eight blue.”

Tears gathered in her eyes. Léa had given her charcoal and graphite, but no one had ever given her color. “I’ve never used pastels.”

“They’re meant to make you happy, not sad.” He pointed at the box. “They have a soft, chalk-like feel, making them easy to blend and layer.”

“How do they make the colors so vibrant?” She lifted one from the tray; it was like holding a bolt of light.

“They have a higher concentration of pigment and much less binder. And with the softness, you can produce a broader range of expressive strokes.”

“I don’t know how to thank you.” She worried he had spent money on her that he didn’t have or should have spent on buying food for his mother and brothers. “Are you sure you want to give this to me?”

“Only if you promise to draw something for me.”

She studied his face—would she start with those blue eyes that made her melt, his long lashes like black ivy? Or maybe she’d commence with his square chin, the dimple in the middle, the playful smile on his mouth. Perhaps the lovely dark curls in his hair.

“I’ll draw you.”

“Not me.” André laughed. “I’d much rather see the world through your eyes. Show me what I haven’t seen before, and I will be a happy man.” He